

GLOSSARY

Afterlife A life that some people believe begins when you die, for example, a life in heaven or as another person or animal.

Alchemy The medieval forerunner of chemistry focusing on the transmutation of matter, in particular with attempts to convert base metals into gold or to find a potion granting immortality.

Almanac An annual calendar containing important dates and statistical and astronomical information. In the 16th and 17th centuries, almanacs listed dates for church festivals, feast days, and market days, followed by more specific astronomical sections, including times of sunrises and sunsets, and then astrological predictions about the weather, crops, and politics.

Amulet An object, which may be found rather than crafted, such as a beaver's tooth, thought to have magical powers and worn on the body. *See also* Talisman.

Animism The belief that anything natural, such as plants, animals, rocks, water, or thunder, has a spirit and can influence human events.

Apotropaic Magic that can avert evil influences or bad luck.

Astral magic A type of magic that involves the stars and planets, and their spirits.

Astral projection A person's attempt to detach their soul or consciousness, known as the astral body, from their physical form to allow it to travel through the astral realm (between the divine and human planes).

Astrology The practice of studying and interpreting the movements of the stars and planets in the belief that they can influence human lives and events on earth.

Augury Reading omens believed to be present in natural phenomena, such as weather patterns, the flight of birds, or the entrails of sacrificial animals.

Book of Shadows The book used by a practitioner of Wicca to record spells and rituals. Each book is personal to its owner. *See also* Grimoire.

Celestial bodies Objects that move through the sky, such as planets, stars, and the sun and moon. Historically, these were sometimes associated with particular angels or spirits.

Ceremonial magic High or learned magic characterized by the use of ritual, ceremony, and specialized tools or clothing.

Cleromancy Ancient Chinese divinatory practice of casting yarrow stalks to form a solid or broken line, then repeating this action to form six rows and interpreting the resulting hexagram in relation to a particular question. Cleromancy is the basis of the divinatory text *I Ching*.

Conjuring Invoking spirits or practicing illusionist magic.

Crystallomancy The practice of looking into a crystal with the aim of seeing visions within it, often for divination; also known as crystal gazing.

Cunning folk Also known as healers, practitioners of medicine, magic, and divination within the context of local traditions in Christian Europe. Services included midwifery, magical protection, healing, and matchmaking.

Curse A solemn utterance that is intended to invoke a supernatural power to inflict harm or punishment on someone or something.

Curse tablet A small tablet with a curse written on it, usually from the Greco-Roman world. Curse tablets were used to ask the gods, spirits, or a deceased person to perform an action on a person or object, or otherwise compel the subject of the curse.

Deity A god or goddess (in a polytheistic religion such as Hinduism); the creator and supreme being (in a monotheistic religion such as Christianity); also denotes divine status, quality, or nature.

Demon Wicked spirit able to access occult powers; demonology is the study of demons. In Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, the Devil is the most powerful demon.

Demonic magic A definition, originating in the medieval period, for magic whose effects were thought to be achieved through the powers of demons, and therefore to be intrinsically sinful.

Divination The skill or practice of discovering or saying what will happen in the future.

Doctrine of signatures The belief that natural objects that looked like a part of the body could cure diseases that would arise there. Christian and Muslim folk healers in the medieval era claimed that God, or Allah, deliberately made plants resemble the parts of the body they were able to cure. For example, eyebright, a plant whose flower looks like bright blue eyes, was used in the treatment of eye diseases. *See also* Sympathetic magic.

Ectoplasm A substance that is believed to surround ghosts and other creatures connected with spiritual activities.

Effigy A representation of a specific person in the form of sculpture or some other three-dimensional medium.

Enochian magic A type of ceremonial magic, developed by John Dee and Edward Kelley, that aims to invoke and control various spirits.

Equinox Either of the two occasions in the year (spring or fall) when the center of the sun is directly above the equator, and day and night are of equal length; celebrated by Neopagans as two of the Sabbats.